Thanks, Nurse

By Diane Carlson Evans

INTRODUCTION

When Diane Carlson Evans, a former army nurse in Vietnam, first saw the Vietnam Veterans Memorial, she felt something was missing. Her efforts to highlight the service of women in Vietnam were rewarded on November 11, 1993, when the Vietnam Women's Memorial was dedicated. The women's war was different from the men's -- instead of exploding in the jungle, it blew up in the mind. Surrounded by death, the nurses had to shut down emotionally. They could not show their feelings to the soldiers they were trying to heal. Thanks, Nurse by Diane Carlson Evans.

November 13th, 1982

I stand beside the Vietnam Veterans Memorial.

Pleiku, is written on my wrinkled jungle hat, and

71st Evacuation Hospital, Vietnam.

Wearing it today feels natural

Even with a skirt and among strangers.

Thirteen years ago it found its place

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In a foot locker with worn out combat boots,

Fatigues, a malaria net and poncho liner.

Strange memorabilia for a young woman of 22 years.

A foot locker filled with memories

Of a lifetime of one year and

Locked away, forever - I had hoped,

Until today.

"Thanks, Nurse," that day in Washington. D.C.

You, with your boonie hat and

Faded camouflage

Threw your arms around me, and said

"Thanks, nurse, I never had a chance to say that"

The tears rolled down my face,

Don't make me cry,

I've passed thirteen years without a tear.

Please, don't remind me of sadness

With that look on your face.

My soul was overwhelmed with

Emotion I hadn't felt

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Since leaving that faraway war
In 1969.
"You nurses saved our lives, you know, we
Love you,"
My tears are uncontrollable, and
I am as much with the
Dead as with the living.
Facing the sall, I encounter
Something I left behind me so many
Years ago.
I am at that moment lifted away
And reunited with those who suffered
And died and had left me
Alone.
Left me alone, with the memories of them.
And left me too numb to dry.
As I put my hands on the hard granite
And touched the names of those who
Died, 1968-'69, I no longer
Felt alone.

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Those who had died, came back
at that moment,
Allowed me to grieve, embraced me
And touched a part of my
Soul I had thought was gone.
That vague place in my Life,
Vietnam, which could not bring forth
Emotion or feelings
Or tears.
It was such a relief to cry now, to
Feel again. It was so strange.
I felt unbearable sadness, and yet
Set free - free of an intangible
Burden.

That beautiful black granite
Wall, now carries the burden
For me
And for us all.
It carries the names and souls,

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The memories, of those who died
In Vietnam.
It shelters them with respect
And dignity.

"Nurse, I don't want to die here," they would say
"Will I make it home? Oh God, don't let me die here."
That look in their eyes - so young, so serious,
Please don't make me remember.
The longing for home among the
Wounded was so strong.
We worked so hard to "get them home."
And thousands we did,
But for those who died we were
Sorry they couldn't have their last wish.

It would not have been their
Last wish - to be on this wall
Their life had just begun -
"Nurse I want to get home."

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Now they are home and
Are again with their fallen
Friends.
The memorial that honors the living
And the dead, by giving us
a Place
To join together.

To you in your faded camouflage
And boonie hats and
Green berets, I want to say
Thank you" too, from someone who
Cared for you in Vietnam, and
Still cares today. "Thank you too"
For you see, you, and this wall
Set me free
Free to cry and free to remember,
What I had hoped to forget
And found I could not.

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If our country could have known
But one dying man, alone in Vietnam
With that look on his face
And hopelessness in his eyes
If this country could have seen
The courage he had and concern
For his friends
If this country could have
Wept in his tears
And told him he was good.
If only, this country would have
Listened - listened and learned of his
Experience and his sacrifice
And then told him they were
Proud. If only there would have been
"Thanks."

We sacrificed our youth
I'm not sure why
How does one explain, to those

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Who didn't go
The fear, the suffering, the inhumanity,
It's not what we wanted
To have names on this wall,
Or to visit a Place such as this but
It was a real war
And we are real veterans.

Now this country has wept
In our tears from that era
By watching us stand proudly, honorably, beside
The Names, our comrades.
Sons and daughters at war do not know why
They are chosen ones to sacrifice.
But we stand proud and we will not
Let our nation forget our
Comrades.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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